

Northside Home Goods

Acceptable Use Policy (AUP)

Version: 1.0 | Applies To: All Employees, Contractors, and Third-Party Users

1. Purpose and Scope

This Acceptable Use Policy defines the acceptable and ethical use of Northside Home Goods' information systems and technology resources. The goal is to keep our retail operations, customer data, and financial systems secure while giving employees a clear, practical guide to what's expected of them.

This policy applies to all 40 employees, contractors, temporary staff, and any third parties accessing Northside Home Goods networks, Point-of-Sale (POS) systems, e-commerce platforms, or cloud infrastructure.

2. General Use and Ownership

- 1. Corporate Property:** All information systems, email accounts, POS terminals, hardware, and software provided by Northside Home Goods are company property.
- 2. No Expectation of Privacy:** Northside Home Goods reserves the right to audit, inspect, and monitor all network traffic, email communications, and device activity on corporate resources. Users should have no expectation of privacy when using corporate systems.
- 3. Incidental Personal Use:** Occasional personal use of corporate devices — checking a personal email during a break, for example — is permitted as long as it doesn't interfere with work, consume excessive bandwidth, or violate anything in this policy.

3. Password and Authentication Standards

Strong authentication is the most straightforward defense against unauthorized access to business systems.

- **Complexity and Length:** All work-related passwords must be at least 16 characters. Passphrases are strongly recommended — something like *blue-coffee-sunrise-retail* is both longer and easier to remember than a short string of random characters.
- **Protection:** Passwords must never be shared with coworkers, written on sticky notes near POS terminals, or reused across personal and corporate accounts.
- **Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA):** MFA is required for all access to cloud systems, email, financial tools, and the e-commerce admin portal. Disabling or bypassing MFA is not permitted under any circumstances.

4. Prohibited Activities

The following activities are not permitted on Northside Home Goods systems or networks:

- **Bypassing Security:** Attempting to circumvent security controls, access data you're not authorized to see, or use tools designed to crack passwords or intercept network traffic.
- **Unauthorized Software:** Installing personal software, unapproved browser extensions, or freeware on retail endpoints or corporate laptops without IT approval.
- **Inappropriate Content:** Accessing, storing, or transmitting pornographic, hateful, discriminatory, or otherwise illicit material.
- **Data Mishandling:** Forwarding internal business communications, customer lists, or payment card information to personal email accounts or unauthorized third-party cloud storage.
- **Shared Accounts:** Logging into a POS terminal or cloud application using another employee's credentials or an unauthorized generic admin account.

5. Email and Communications

- Corporate email is for business use. Don't use it to sign up for personal services, promotions, or social media accounts.
- Be cautious with email. Any message requesting an invoice change, wire transfer, vendor payment update, or urgent password reset should be verified by a separate channel — phone call or in person — before acting on it. Report suspicious emails to IT immediately.
- Don't click links or download attachments from senders you don't recognize. If you're not sure, forward it to IT rather than clicking.

6. Payment and Customer Data Handling

Northside Home Goods processes customer payment card information and personal data as part of daily operations. Mishandling that data creates legal, financial, and reputational risk for the company and the customers it serves.

- Payment card numbers, expiration dates, and CVV codes must never be stored locally, written down, photographed, or transmitted via email or messaging apps.
- Customer personal information — names, addresses, purchase history, contact details — should only be accessed by employees whose job requires it.
- Don't share customer data with vendors or other third parties unless you've confirmed with management that a data sharing agreement is in place.
- If you believe a customer's payment data has been compromised — or if the POS system behaves unexpectedly — report it to IT immediately. Don't try to investigate it yourself.

7. Administrative Access Controls

Some employees have administrative access to business systems — the ability to create accounts, change settings, or access data beyond what a standard user sees. That access comes with additional responsibility.

- Admin credentials should not be used for routine daily tasks. Use your standard account for day-to-day work and switch to an admin account only when the task requires it.
- Admin accounts must use MFA and a strong, unique password that isn't reused anywhere else.
- If you notice unexpected changes to system settings, new user accounts you didn't create, or access you don't recognize, report it to the Operations Manager or IT Lead right away.
- Log out of administrative portals after each session. Don't leave admin sessions open and unattended.

8. Policy Sanctions and Enforcement

Compliance with this policy is required. Violations may result in disciplinary action, up to and including termination of employment or the end of a contractor engagement. If a violation involves potentially illegal activity, Northside Home Goods will cooperate with law enforcement.

By using Northside Home Goods systems, you acknowledge that you have read, understood, and agree to follow this policy.

Employee Name (Print)	Signature	Date

Northside Home Goods is a fictional company created for portfolio purposes. All policies in this folder are fictional and don't represent any real company or client. This isn't insurance, legal, or underwriting advice.

Policy template note: This sample policy was adapted conceptually from SANS Institute policy templates. It is not an official SANS document, and SANS Institute retains all rights to its original materials.